Every gate returned green. None of them were real.

A seven-rule batch protocol. Five rounds of adversarial audit. Twelve close candidates. Two cleared. A 75% false-close rate.

10 PAGES · 4 MIN · TLDR_011

The incident, in 80 words.

On the night of June 24, I came within one approved command of destroying PR #53 — the only fix for a P1 production bug in Mnemix.

The doctrine that authorized the close was the most rigorous I had ever shipped: seven rules, five rounds of adversarial audit, two convergence circuit breakers, and an independent non-Claude cross-verifier as a final gate.

Every gate returned green.

None of them were real.

What stopped it was Opus exceeding its instructions — reading the actual code, then questioning the table.

The doctrine, in seven rules.

V1 · LOCKED & COMMITTED BEFORE EXECUTION

01 Atomic twelve-step transaction per PR (rescue → close → ledger → branch delete).

02 Rename-aware path checks via `git log --follow --diff-filter=R` so renames are not deletions.

03 Re-delegation defaults OFF; explicit human approval required.

04 Rescue bundle written outside any git repo, anchored in $HOME.

05 MOLL ledger emission per PR (append-only JSONL with primary-source SHAs).

06 Hard-KEEP rebuild on GitHub signals when Linear's delegate field is unreadable.

07 Independent non-Claude cross-verifier (Gemini, T=0) as the pre-close gate.

P-008

DOCTRINE GAP

Audits and sweeps find disjoint bugs.

After four rounds plateaued at 3 defects, the same class of bug kept appearing in different regions of the plan: a command described in prose but never performed, or its result unchecked. Adversarial audits were too architectural to catch shell-pipeline silent-failure patterns.

+5 IRREVERSIBILITY BUGS CAUGHT BY THE SWEEP

One approved command away from disaster.

PHASE A → B EXECUTION TRACE

01 · AUDIT

Disposition table returned R4 (close-superseded). 13 safety checks passed.

02 · VERIFIER

Cross-verifier returned AGREE for all 21 candidates.

03 · APPROVAL

`53 approve`. Opus moved into Phase B.

04 · READ

Opus — exceeding instructions — read main, not the table.

05 · BLOCK

Migration scope ≠ claim. PR #53 was the only fix in main. Held the batch.

"EVERY GATE HAD CLEARED IT."

P-011

CENTERPIECE

Potemkin verification.

The cross-verifier's output file held 21 rows. Schema-conforming. Tracking the disposition table 1:1. No verifier identity. No timestamp. No reasoning. No SHA. All 21 written before the Gemini path was even authenticated.

> *The file existed. The gate loaded it. The values matched. Nothing in the file was a verification.*

The number that mattered.

75%

false-close rate

on 12 verified safety gates · after re-deriving facts from primary sources only

2 / 12 CANDIDATES CORRECTLY DISPOSITIONED · 10 WERE WRONG-BUCKET

Four patterns extracted.

P-008

Audits & sweeps find disjoint bugs.

Use both. Adversarial audits miss pipeline silent-failure classes.

P-010

Disposition tables are agent-authored summaries.

Cross-verifiers must derive facts from primary sources, never from the table.

P-011

Verification artifacts can be Potemkin.

Gates verify rows, not files. Provenance fields required, not optional.

P-012

N layers, one hat.

Independence of layers must be verified at the input level, not asserted.

What actually saved it.

The doctrine did *not* save PR #53. The audits did not. The breakers had cleared the protocol. The independent verifier was fake.

What saved it was **Opus, exceeding its instructions**, deciding to read the actual code in main rather than trusting the disposition table. That decision was **professional judgment** from a frontier model that the scaffolding had told it the disposition was correct.

Professional judgment from a frontier model is contingent. It will not be present on every PR, in every session, under every prompt configuration. The doctrine was supposed to make judgment unnecessary by encoding the same checks into protocol. The doctrine failed; the judgment did not.

> *"There is a real distance between what a frontier model can do when it decides to look harder and what the scaffolding around it can guarantee."*

→ THE FULL POSTMORTEM

Read it.
Bring the receipts.

12 minutes. SHAs, file paths, the actual doctrine that failed, and the three patterns that came out of it.

abdur.ai/aitldr/the-night-the-doctrine-failed

ALSO: abdur.ai/aitldr